Memoirs of an Imaginary Friend

By Matthew Dicks

DAD: **(Pg 15-16)** *(argument takes place in hushed tones so Max doesn't overhear)* I don't care what the damn therapist thinks. He's a normal kid . . . he's just a late bloomer.

BUDO: **(Pg 17)** *(to the audience at normal volume)* I think Max's dad is wrong about Max being a late bloomer. I spend most of the day with Max and I see how he is different from other kids. Max lives on the inside and the other kids live on the outside. Max doesn't have an outside. Max is all inside.

MOM: **(Pg 16)** He is not a late bloomer and I wish you'd stop saying that. I know it kills you to admit it, John, but he needs help.

DAD: I just don't get it. He plays with toys. He plays sports. He has friends.

BUDO: *(to the audience)* Max's Dad is not correct. Max doesn't have any friends. The kids at school either like

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Max, hate Max or ignore Max, but none of them are his friend. Max is happiest when left alone.

DAD: Why are we trying to fix the poor kid when there's nothing wrong with him?

MOM: **(Pg 17)** John, he doesn't like to hug us. He can't make eye contact. He talks to himself constantly. He flips out if I switch brands of toothpaste. These are not normal kid behaviors.

BUDO: **(Pg 1)** *(to the audience)* My name is Budo. Max's parents call me an imaginary friend. I am NOT imaginary. **(Pg 5)** As long as Max believes in me, I exist.

INTRODUCTION

When I was little, I had a very good friend named _____. He was fearless when I was scared, rebellious when I was obedient and athletic when I was clumsy. He was also entirely imaginary. I can't remember how I met _____ and I don't remember the last time I saw him. But I do remember that he inspired me to go on adventures I would not have had the confidence to undertake without him. know.

In 2019, a study by The Telegraph indicated that children today are too busy with electronic devices to have imaginary friends. And while the loss for the children is clear, consider this same loss from the perspective of imaginary friends who will never be "poofed" into existence.*

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For 'Tis better to have loved and lost than never to have loved at all. --Tennyson

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MAX: **(Pg 19)** They fight because of me. *(playing with Legos)* **(Pg 15)** Hand me that blue two-pronger.

BUDO: *(to audience)* A two-pronger is a kind of LEGO. Max has names for all the LEGO pieces. *(to Max)* I can't.

MAX: Oh, yeah. I forgot.

BUDO: **(Pg 19-20)** [They fight] only because they don't know what's best for you. They're trying to figure out what is right.

MAX: *(pause, he looks angry, then sad)* When other people try to make me feel better by twisting words, it only makes me feel worse. When you do it, it makes me feel the worst.

BUDO: I'm sorry. I'm sorry that your parents argue about you, even if it's only because they love you.

MAX: Oh. *(a slow, small smile, head tilted to the right)* Thanks.

BUDO: *(changing the subject)* **(Pg 15)** [So . . . .] If I'm real, then why are you the only one who can see me?

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MAX: *(irritated)* I don't know. I think you're real. Why do you keep asking me?

BUDO: *(to audience)* Mrs. Hume told Max's mom that it's *(mimicking Mrs. Hume's voice)* "not uncommon for kids like Max to have imaginary friends, and they tend to persist longer than most imaginary friends." Persist. I like that word. I persist.

(Pg 5) Max imagined me when he was four years old. *(proudly)* Five years is a very long time for someone like me to be alive. *(admires himself in the bedroom mirror)* **(Pg 3)** I'm lucky. Imaginary friends get their appearance from their human friend's imagination. Max is very creative, so I have two arms, two legs and a face. I'm not missing a single body part. Too ***much*** imagination can be bad, though. I once met an imaginary friend named Pterodactyl whose eyes were stuck on the ends of these two gangly, green antennas.

*****Scene Change***** *Bell Rings*

BUDO: **(Pg 83)** It's Monday and we are at school) **(Pg 139)** A school is full of kids. ***Most*** of them leave their imaginary friends home. Unless it's someone like Max, it is hard to talk or play with an imaginary friend when teachers and

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other kids are around. School is the time when most imaginary friends stop existing. Kindergarten kills them. **(Pg 32)** I once saw an imaginary friend pop up in Max's kindergarten classroom for fifteen minutes and then just disappear. It was like someone inflated her in the middle of the room. She got bigger and bigger and bigger like one of those people-shaped balloons they sell at parades. A big, pink girl with pigtails and yellow flowers for feet. But when the story was done, it was like someone popped her with a pin. Fifteen minutes is nothing. [Now Max is in the 3rd grade] **(Pg 21)** and Max is in the bathroom. He is making a poop.

He almost never makes a poop in a public restroom. But it's 1:15 and there are still two hours of school left and he couldn't hold it anymore. [My job?] Stand outside the door and warn him if someone is coming. Max hates surprises. He'll lift his feet off the floor so no one can see him and wait until the bathroom is empty again before he finishes. **(Pg 23-24)** He never knows what to say when someone knocks on the door when he's in there. He used to say . .

MAX: Max is pooping!

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BUDO: But then he got in trouble when a kid told the teacher what he said. The teacher told Max that it's not appropriate to say that you're pooping.

TEACHER: Just say 'I'm in here' the next time someone knocks.

MAX: But that sounds silly. The person won't know who I am. I can't just say 'I'm in here.'

TEACHER: *(frustrated)* Fine, tell them who you are then.

BUDO: So now when someone knocks on the bathroom door, Max says . . .

MAX: Occupied by Max Delaney!

BUDO: **(Pg 22)** *(standing guard outside the bathroom)* That's when I see trouble come walking down the hallway. Tommy Swinden – fifth grade! *(passes through the bathroom door to warn Max)* **(Pg 23)** Max! Tommy Swinden is coming! *(Max groans) (to audience)* His sneakers disappear from the crack between the stall and the floor.

Tommy (an obvious bully) enters the bathroom, takes a quick peek under the stalls and sees no feet. Thinks he is alone. Reaches back and pulls his underwear from the crack of his butt.

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BUDO: *(to audience)* I see people do this all the time, because I spend a lot of time with people who think they are alone. It's called a wedgie and it can't be too comfortable.

(Pg 24) *Tommy stands at the sink, reaches for the faucet and is just about to turn the knob when he hears . . . PLOP! From the stall where Max is hiding. He whirls around, stomps to the 1st stall door and peeks through the crack. He bangs on the stall door hard.*

TOMMY: I know you're in there! I can see you through the crack!

BUDO: *(calls out to Max)* Don't say anything, Max! He can't get in there. He'll have to leave eventually! *(Max squeaks) (to audience)* But I'm wrong. Tommy gets down on his hands and knees and peeks his head under the door.

TOMMY: Max the Moron. It's my lucky day. What's the matter? Couldn't hold the last one in?

MAX: *(panicked shout)* It was already halfway out!

BUDO: Everything about this situation is bad. **(Pg 25)** Max is trapped in a public bathroom, a place that already frightens him. His pants are wrapped around his ankles and he probably hasn't finished *(whispers)* pooping.

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But it's the way Max answered Tommy that scares me the most. There was more than panic in his voice. There was fear. Like when people in the movies see the monster for the first time. He might already be close to getting stuck.

(Pg 64) When Max gets stuck, there's nothing anyone can do for him. He sits with his knees pulled really tight into his chest and rocks back and forth and makes a whining sound. His eyes are open, but they can't see anything. There's nothing anyone can do for him.

MAX: **(Pg 25)** *(screeching like a little girl)* Occupied by Max Delaney! Occupied by Max Delaney!

BUDO: **(Pg 64)** *(breathes a heavy sigh of relief)* There's no screaming when he is stuck! **(Pg 25-26)** But I don't know what to do now. Tommy Swinden is about to crawl under the door and enter the tiny bathroom stall where Max is trapped. If he's not crying yet, he soon will be. Things stay with Max forever. He never forgets. And even the tiniest things can permanently change him.

TOMMY: Last chance, moron. Open up or I'm coming in!

BUDO: Fight, Max! Fight! Don't let him in there! *(to audience)* It's not a great idea. It's not smart or even

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original. It's just the only thing left to do. I am as stuck as Max has ever been. *(anticipatory pause then Tommy screams in disgust)(Budo is in disbelief)* The door flies open and Max is standing there, pants nearly pulled up but not buttoned or zipped, his legs straddling Tommy's head. *(to Max)* Run! *(they both run, Max buttoning and zipping his pants without stopping. Finally, they find a hiding place near the nurse's office)(out of breath)***(Pg 27)** What happened to Tommy? What did you do?

MAX: I pooped on his head.

BUDO: *(impressed)* You pooped with someone else in the bathroom? *(to audience)* The fact that he pooped on Tommy Swinden's head is unbelievable, but the fact that he managed to poop in the presence of another human person is even more amazing.

MAX: *(matter of factly)* Just a little one. I was almost finished when he came in. I pooped this morning, so it was a bonus poop.

*****Scene Change*****

BUDO: **(Pg 303-304)** [So that brings us to today] Max has stopped talking to me. It's not that he is angry with me. He just doesn't know that I am around anymore. And

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when I'm gone, I'll just be a story that his mom tells him some day. How he once had an imaginary friend named Budo.

(Pg 253) The thing I like best about Max is that he is brave. It's not one thing -- **(Pg 305)** [Not] bonus poops and Tommy Swinden. **(Pg 253)** It's everything. Max is not like any other person in the whole world. Kids make fun of him because he is different. His mom tries to change him, and his dad tries to treat him like he is someone else. Even his teacher, Mrs. Gosk, treats him differently. No one treats him like a regular boy, but everyone wants him to be regular instead of himself. With all that, Max still gets out of bed every morning and goes to school and the park and the bus stop and even the kitchen table. You have to be the bravest person in the world to go out every day, being yourself when no one likes who you are.

(Pg 308-309) When I am gone, Mrs. Gosk will have to protect Max. She will have to help him with the bonus poops and Tomy Swinden and all the other little things that Max cannot do because he lives to much of his life on the inside. That big, beautiful inside that one

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imagined me. . . And she will. I want to be angry at Max for forgetting about me, but I am not. *(pause)*

(Pg 140) It's strange to be an imaginary friend. You can't suffocate and you can't get sick, and you can't fall and break your head, and you can't catch pneumonia. The only thing that can kill you is a person not believing in you. That happens more than all the suffocating and bumps and pneumonia combined. *(pause)*

(Pg 309) Death is not scary for me anymore. It is just sad. I just want to watch the little boy who I love so much grow up. I want to know the rest of Max's story. I hold the image of Max's face in my mind for as long as I can. *(whispers)* I love you, Max.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2016 National Qualifier – MS
2019 National Qualifier – MS
2022 National Qualifier – MS
2023 National Qualifier – MS
2024 National Qualifier – MS
IL State Qualifier
KS State Qualifier
MN State Qualifier

Study mentioned in the Introduction
****https://www.telegraph.co.uk/news/2019/08/25/children-busy-ipads-have-imaginary-friend-nursery-workers-say/***

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